COUNTER SALES ESSENTIALS

Counter Sales Essentials — Level 1 — Day 5: Closing, Getting the Order Right, and Your First 90 Days

Study guide · Self-study

Level 1 · Day 5: Closing, Getting the Order Right, and Your First 90 Days

How to Use This Guide

Welcome to Day 5. You have learned how to open a counter conversation, find the job behind the request, recommend the right item, add what the job really needs, and handle objections. Today you put it all together and finish the sale.

Work through this guide alone, at your own pace. Write your answers in the space where they belong. Say your lines out loud so they sound like you, not like a script.

You do not need a counter job to practice today. Every exercise gives you a no-job-yet option: role-play with a friend, record yourself on your phone, use the fictional customer given here, or watch how staff serve you at a real counter as a customer. If you already work at a counter, you can use your real customers, but never real names, account details or personal data.

Practice first, then read the model answers at the end. The models are examples, not scripts. The principle behind each answer matters more than the exact words.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know the five steps of the Commitment Close and the checks that make an order, payment and receipt correct.

Attitude: You will see closing as the logical end of a good conversation, not as pressure, and accept that the customer can always say no.

Skill: You will be able to close a counter sale with a genuine choice, confirm an order item by item, and turn a first sale into a regular customer with honest follow-up.

Upskill: You will be able to show these skills out loud in a hiring role-play or interview, and plan how to learn on the job in your first 90 days.

Closing with the Commitment Close

Most new counter sellers find closing the hardest part. They worry about sounding pushy, so they trail off, or they ask a weak question and watch the customer walk away to "think about it."

The Commitment Close (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Voss, Kahneman, Dixon and Adamson, and Cialdini) fixes this. It is MEDJAY's close: the logical conclusion of the process, not pressure, and the customer can still say no. It has five steps, used in order:

Criteria: Restate the customer's own criteria.

Evidence: Show the evidence against those criteria.

Consequence: Name the consequences honestly, including when waiting is better.

Calibrated question: Ask a What or How question.

Genuine choice: Offer real choices of next step, with a date.

Why does this work on the customer's mind? Two reasons. First, people push back when they feel cornered. Psychologists call this reactance: pressure creates resistance (Brehm, 1966). When you leave the customer's right to say no fully intact, there is nothing to push against, so the guard comes

down. Second, people commit more firmly to decisions they made themselves. Restating the customer's own criteria hands the decision back to them, in their own words.

The calibrated question matters. "What would you need to see to take it today?" is a question the customer must think about. "Shall I put it through?" invites a reflex no. Use a What or How question every time.

Practice example: A customer at a hardware counter needs to fix a leaking pipe before family arrive on Saturday. You have confirmed the fitting and the sealant. You say: "You told me it has to hold through Saturday and you want to do it once, properly. (Criteria) This fitting and this sealant are the pair that match your pipe, and both are in stock. (Evidence) If we leave it and the leak spreads, you could be facing a bigger repair on Friday night. (Consequence) What would you need to see to take both today? (Calibrated question) Would you like to take them now, or shall I put them aside for you until this evening? (Genuine choice)"

Notice the last step: a genuine choice of next step, with a date. Never end with a yes/no question like "Shall we go ahead?"

Getting the Order, Payment and Receipt Right

The sale is not done when the customer says yes. It is done when they leave with the right item, the right paperwork and no surprises. Most returns at a counter start with a small mistake at this step, not with the product.

Confirm the order item by item, out loud. Read back the item, the size, the model or the quantity. Ask the customer to check the part number or the label with you. This is not distrust; it is care, and customers feel it.

Then confirm payment plainly: the total, the method, and any change. Finally, the receipt: hand it over, point to the return window and say what it covers.

Why does this matter so much? A wrong item costs the customer a second trip, and a second trip costs you their trust. Trust works like an emotional bank account: kept promises and small courtesies are deposits, letdowns are withdrawals (Covey, 1989). One wrong part undoes many good conversations.

Watch the pace here. When the queue is long, it is tempting to rush the check. Accuracy beats speed. A thirty-second read-back prevents a return that takes ten minutes to fix.

Turning a First Sale into a Regular

A walk-in customer who leaves happy is a possible regular. A regular trade customer who trusts you is the backbone of a counter. The move from one to the other is small, honest follow-up.

Keep it simple. When you hand over the receipt, tell the customer when you are usually at the counter. If they are starting a bigger job, say what else they will likely need and when. If you ordered something for them, note when it arrives.

Do not overdo it. One useful sentence beats a sales pitch. The customer remembers that you thought ahead for them, not that you tried to sell them more.

For trade customers, the follow-up is about reliability. They come back because you get it right the first time and because you tell them honestly when you cannot.

Practice example: A painting customer buys brushes and tape. As you hand over the receipt you say: "If you are doing the whole room, you will likely need more tape halfway through. I am here most mornings, so come back and I will have it ready." That is a deposit in the trust account, not a push.

Managing the Queue, the Phone and Busy Hours

The customer in front of you must never feel rushed, and the queue must keep moving. Both are possible if you acknowledge the people waiting.

When someone joins the queue, make eye contact and say you will be with them shortly. When the phone rings, answer it briefly and tell the caller you will call back, or ask them to hold while you finish with the customer in front of you. Never let the phone take priority over a person standing at your counter.

Waiting feels longer than it is, especially when nobody explains it (Maister, 1985). A customer who has been acknowledged waits more patiently than one who has been ignored. That is why a short "I see you, I will be right with you" changes the mood of a whole queue.

Showing These Skills in a Hiring Role-Play or Interview

Hiring managers for counter roles are not looking for a polished pitch. They are looking for someone calm, accurate and honest with customers.

In a role-play, they will play a customer with a request or a complaint. Show the full counter sale: greet, find the job, recommend, handle any pushback, close with a genuine choice, confirm the order. Speak slowly. Pause before answering hard questions, as you learned on Day 4.

In an interview, they will ask how you would serve a difficult customer. Answer with a short story: the situation, what you did, what happened. Keep it to about a minute.

Your First 90 Days on the Job

Once you start, your first weeks set the pattern. Learn the product range first: the top sellers, the common substitutes, and where to look things up fast. Learn who to ask when you do not know. Asking for help early is a strength, not a weakness; it prevents wrong orders.

In your first month, focus on accuracy and the First-Contact Standard. In your second and third month, focus on add-ons that fit the job, and on building regulars. Ask for feedback on specific behaviors, not on your personality.

Apply It in Your Role

If you already work at a counter: today, close one sale with the full Commitment Close and read back every order out loud. Notice how the customer reacts.

If you do not have a counter job yet: pick one counter setting from this course, such as auto parts or a phone counter. Write the five steps of the Commitment Close for one fictional customer in that setting. Then say them out loud until they sound natural.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you look at the model answers. Keep your answers general.

1. A customer has chosen a drill and confirmed it fits their job. They hesitate and say, "I might look around first." What do you say?

2. You have just handed a customer their change and receipt, and they start to walk away with the wrong size fitting. What do you say?

3. In an interview, you are asked: "Tell me about a time you helped someone get what they actually needed." What is your one-minute answer?

Key Takeaways

- Closing is the logical end of a good conversation, not pressure. The customer keeps the right to say no.
- The Commitment Close has five steps in order: Criteria, Evidence, Consequence, Calibrated question, Genuine choice. It never ends with a yes/no question.
- Confirm every order item by item and hand over the receipt with a plain explanation. Accuracy beats speed.
- Small, honest follow-up turns a first sale into a regular or trade customer.
- Keep the customer in front of you calm and the queue moving by acknowledging everyone who waits.
- In a hiring role-play, show the full counter sale out loud. Managers hire calm, accurate and honest people.
- In your first 90 days, learn the product range and ask for help early.

Quiz

Answer the five questions below. Choose one option for each.

1. What is the correct order of the steps of the Commitment Close?

A. Criteria, Evidence, Consequence, Calibrated question, Genuine choice

B. Acknowledge, Reframe, Transition, Calibrated question, Genuine choice

C. Anchor, Illuminate, Mobilize, Calibrated question, Genuine choice

D. Evidence, Criteria, Consequence, Genuine choice, Calibrated question

2. Why does leaving the customer's right to say no make a yes more likely?

   A. It makes the customer feel the price is lower

   B. Pressure creates resistance, so removing pressure lowers the guard

   C. It speeds up the queue

   D. It removes the need for a receipt

3. A customer has chosen a product that fits their job. Which is the strongest closing question?

   A. Shall I put it through for you?

   B. Would you like to sign up?

   C. Can I send the contract?

   D. What would you need to see to take it today?

4. What is the right way to confirm an order at the counter?

   A. Read back each item, size and quantity, then confirm payment and receipt

   B. Hand over the item and let the customer check it at home

   C. Ask the customer to come back tomorrow to confirm

   D. Skip the check when the queue is long

5. In a hiring role-play, what shows a manager you can serve a customer well?

   A. A fast, polished pitch about the product

   B. A long story about your hobbies

   C. The full counter sale: greet, find the job, recommend, handle pushback, close, confirm

   D. Agreeing to every request the customer makes

Upskill Challenge

Before your next practice, complete this challenge. It works whether or not you have a counter job.

Role-play a full counter sale with a friend. Use the fictional customer from this guide, or invent one from a counter setting. Take it all the way to the Commitment Close. Record it on your phone and watch it back.

Do a mock order check with your friend. Read back three items out loud, then confirm payment and the receipt.

Write and rehearse a 60-second interview answer that shows how you serve a customer through the full counter sale. Say it out loud three times.

☐ Role-play completed with the full Commitment Close

☐ Recording watched back

☐ Mock order check done with three items

☐ 60-second interview answer written

☐ Interview answer rehearsed out loud three times

> **NOTES**
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> Common mistake: ending with "Shall I put it through?" Go back and replace it with a What or How question, or a real choice with a date.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

1. "You have found the drill that fits your job. Looking around often ends in a second trip and a fitting that does not match. What would you need to see to take it today? Would you like to take it now, or shall I put it aside for you until later today?" Here you restate their criteria, name the consequence honestly, then ask a What question and offer a real choice.

2. "Excuse me, let me check that with you. I want to be sure it is the right size before you go." Then read back the size against the label together. This is care, not distrust, and it prevents a return.

3. "A customer at a counter needed a part to fix a leak before weekend guests arrived. I asked what the job was, found the right fitting and sealant, and checked both matched their pipe. When they hesitated, I restated their deadline, named what could happen if the leak spread, and asked what they would need to see to take both. They took both and came back the next week for more." Keep it to about a minute, and end with what happened.

Quiz answers:

1. A. The Commitment Close runs Criteria, Evidence, Consequence, Calibrated question, Genuine choice, in that order.

2. B. Pressure creates resistance, so when you leave the right to say no, the customer's guard comes down.

3. D. A What question is a calibrated question; the other three are yes/no closes.

4. A. Read back every item out loud, then confirm payment and receipt; accuracy beats speed.

5. C. Managers look for the full counter sale shown out loud, not a polished pitch.

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